

By Aditi Pai

If New York has the Statue of Liberty, Mumbai will soon be able to boast of a towering Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj memorial. That's the gift the Democratic Front Government has planned for Maharashtra to commemorate the golden jubilee year of the state's birth. Standing at 309 ft in the Arabian Sea, the statue will have the Maratha warrior atop a horse, surrounded by lush gardens and a museum with rare artefacts from the era. The grand celebrations come at a price of over Rs 300 crore. But it's not the cost that is giving politicians sleepless nights; the memorial committee is locked in a bitter caste battle that is seeing political parties jump in to stake their claim to the 17th-century ruler.

Credited with setting up a Hindu empire in the state, Shivaji espoused the ideology of Hindavi Swaraj or freedom for Hindustan. His battles with the regional sultanates established him as a Hindu icon for some; for others, he is the brave war hero who mastered the art of guerrilla warfare. For centuries after his death, Shivaji has caught the attention of historians, poets and politicians alike. Several plays, films and books have been written on the warrior who ruled the Maratha Empire till 1640. Various regional political parties have invoked his name to garner support and win votes. "Shivaji is one of the few historical legacies that Maharashtra can be genuinely proud of. But over time, the real in the history has given way to the imagined as well," says Suhas Palshikar, professor of political science at Pune University.

For years, political parties have staked claim to selective parts of the Maratha warrior's legacy to strengthen their foothold in the state. The Shiv Sena was founded and then later grew on the claims that it followed the principles of Shivaji, a saviour of the Hindus. During its regime in the state between 1995 and 1999, the Sena-BJP underlined their Shivaji theme by renaming city landmarks after the ruler. The NCP is cashing in on

The Battle for SHIVAJI

Plans for a memorial on the Maratha hero run into trouble as political parties jostle for gains



A STATUE OF SHIVAJI; (RIGHT) SHIV SENA'S UDDHAV THACKERAY AND MANOHAR JOSHI WITH THE SHIV VADA; A STILL FROM THE FILM MEE SHIVAJI RAJE BHOSLE BOLTOY

BHASKAR PAUL